

FOR NEWLY ADOPTED DOGS

The 3-3-3 Decompression Tracker

3 Days · 3 Weeks · 3 Months

A gentle, structured guide to help your rescue or shelter dog
settle in — one step at a time.

FORM & FERN

Days 1–3: Let Them Decompress

Check off each day. Don't worry about progress yet — just safety and quiet.

- ☐ Quiet space set up: bed, water, and a low-traffic spot to retreat to
- ☐ Leash on for every outdoor bathroom break (even in a fenced yard)
- ☐ No visitors, parties, or dog park trips this week
- ☐ Offered food in a calm, low-pressure spot — no pressure to eat right away
- ☐ Let them choose where to rest — did not force cuddles or attention
- ☐ Kept walks short and low-stimulation, away from busy areas
- ☐ Noticed today's appetite and sleep: normal, restless, or hiding
- ☐ Noted any triggers seen today (loud noises, strangers, other pets, etc.)
- ☐ Gave them permission to just be a dog — no training pressure yet

Weeks 1–3: Building Routine

Now that the dust has settled, start layering in gentle structure.

- ☐ Feeding and bathroom breaks are becoming predictable and consistent
- ☐ Introduced a consistent bedtime and wake-up routine
- ☐ Started short, positive-only training sessions (5–10 minutes)
- ☐ Practiced their name and one basic cue in a quiet space
- ☐ Slowly introduced one new person or place, one at a time
- ☐ Watched body language during new experiences (tail, ears, posture)
- ☐ Began identifying their specific comfort signals vs. stress signals
- ☐ Explored the house room-by-room at their own pace
- ☐ Started building a positive association with the crate or resting spot

Months 1–3: Settling In For Good

Trust deepens here. This is where their real personality starts to show.

- ☐ Personality is coming through — noted what makes them, them
- ☐ Responding to their name and basic cues consistently
- ☐ Has one or more clear favorite people, places, or toys
- ☐ Comfortable being left alone for short periods
- ☐ Scheduled or completed a wellness check-up appointment
- ☐ Socialization is progressing at their own pace, not on a deadline
- ☐ Identified their long-term triggers and a plan to manage them
- ☐ Considered whether a certified trainer's support would help
- ☐ Gave yourself credit for the patience this journey has taken

Safe Space & Signs of Progress

A quick-reference checklist for setup and encouraging signs to watch for.

- ☐ Designated a quiet 'safe zone' away from foot traffic
- ☐ Set up a crate or bed with a blanket that has a familiar scent
- ☐ Gates or doors set up so they can retreat without being cornered
- ☐ Water available in 1–2 consistent, easy-to-find spots
- ☐ Sign of progress: taking treats gently from your hand
- ☐ Sign of progress: choosing to be in the same room as you
- ☐ Sign of progress: a relaxed body — soft eyes, loose tail, normal breathing
- ☐ Sign of progress: a full-body shake-off after stress (a great sign!)
- ☐ Sign of progress: seeking you out for comfort